Steps to Solving a Problem

1. Identify the problem.

What is the problem?

Is it a big problem, a medium problem, or a small problem?

How can you help to make this problem smaller or to help it go away completely?

Self-Talk: Okay, I have a problem and it is _____.

I need to stay calm and_____.

2. Think of solutions.

You need to listen to the person trying to help you to see if he or she has ideas for good choices you can make to help solve your problem.

You have choices that may help you to "solve" the problem. When we say we're "problem solving," what we really mean is that we're doing something to make the problem smaller. We may not actually make it completely go away!

An example is if you refuse to do your homework, but then you finally decide to get it done though you turn it in late. You may not get as much credit for it, but it was a far better choice than not doing it at all. So you made the problem smaller. We call that "problem solving."

List two good choices that would help to make your problem smaller:

1.
2.

Self-Talk: Okay, I have some choices that could be solutions. By staying calm I can focus on which would be the better choice or if I should use both of them. Sometimes we use several choices to solve one problem.

3. Think about the consequences and put a plan in motion!

We're always looking a bit into the future when we problem solve. We try and figure out what we want to happen if we choose one choice or another choice. Figuring out what will happen next based on a choice we make is called determining the "consequences." We usually like consequences that make a situation less stressful, make ourselves and others calmer, and/or help us get done what we need to do!

© 2011 Social Thinking Publishing

For each of your choices above, write out a consequence that will happen if you use that choice:

Consequence for Choice 1:_____

Consequence for Choice 2:_____

4. Choose your choice(s) and make a plan.

a. Select which choice or choices will help you reach the result you want. Now, make a plan to put your choice into action. This means you will have to take action. Use the questions below to help you figure out how and when to do what needs to be done:

b. Getting going with choices:

1. When will you do it?

2. What do you need to say or do?

3. To whom do you need to say it? (Skip this step if there's nothing to say!)

4. Where do you need to do it?

5. When do you need to do it?

6. How will you reward yourself for getting it done? (Sometimes our rewards are simply telling ourselves we did a good job and reminding ourselves that we're getting better at solving our problems! Rewards aren't always about getting something we want. Eliminating stress can be a huge reward!!)

5. Evaluate the outcome.

Did the solution work? Why or why not?

What could you have done differently?

How can you avoid a similar problem in the future?

Oh yeah, and by the way, CONGRATULATIONS!

© 2011 Social Thinking Publishing